Introduction

THE BRICS AS A CLUB

THE EXTRAORDINARY INCREASE in the economic capabilities and political reach of emerging powers over the past three decades has propelled rising multipolarity in the interstate system. The most influential of these rising powers—Brazil, Russia, India, and China—formed a multilateral club known as the *BRIC*s. This exclusive club began when the countries' ministers met at Russia's invitation on the sidelines of a U.N. General Assembly session in September 2006, and then in May 2008 at a formal quadripartite foreign ministers meeting.[1] The relatively fast ascent (or resurgence, in the case of Russia) of the BRICs made them the natural challengers of the global system dominated by the major incumbent powers constituting the Group of 7 (G7), with the United States as the hegemon.[2] In November 2008, as the world was reeling from the global financial crisis, the BRICs' finance ministers also started consultations on the sidelines of meetings of the newly reconstituted Group of 20 (G20) finance ministers and leaders. BRICS leaders subsequently upgraded their collaboration via a formal summit as their heads of state met for the first time in Yekaterinburg, Russia, in June 2009.

Jim O'Neill, then chief economist at the New York investment bank Goldman Sachs, coined the BRICs acronym in 2001 to refer to a hot new investment fund showcasing the bank's projection that the combined gross domestic product (GDP) of these four large, fast-growing economies would exceed that of the advanced G7 countries by the middle of the century, a timeline soon pushed forward to the 2020s.[3] In a fantastic feat of jujitsu, the Kremlin appropriated the idea of the BRICs from Goldman and reinvented it as a diplomatic club for the four countries to coordinate their shared interests in reforming global governance institutions and gaining greater international influence. Boosting the prestige of both the investment fund and the new political club, the BRICs went on to become what the *Financial Times* called "a near ubiquitous financial term, shaping how a generation of investors, financiers, and policymakers view the emerging markets."[4]